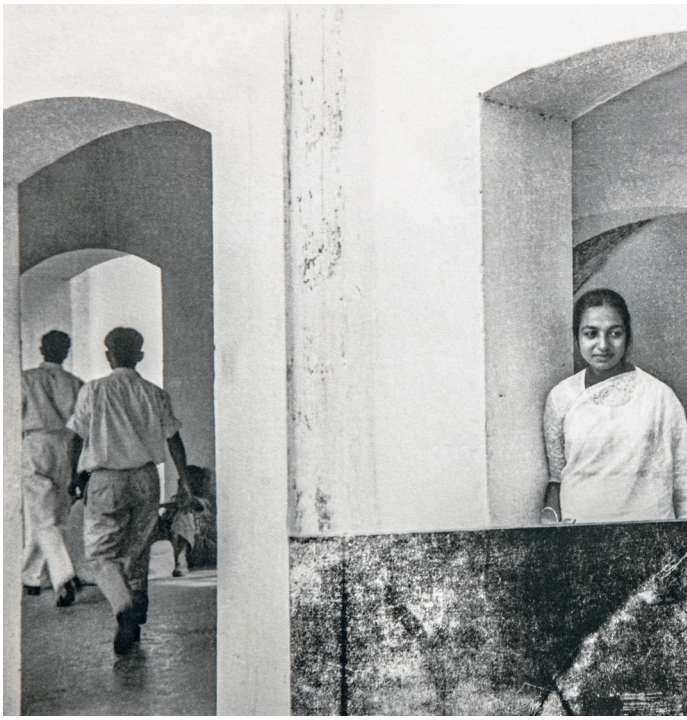
ART

SATORI LINES

A rare collection of artworks by the late abstractionist Nasreen Mohamedi reveals her philosophical outlook and love for minimalism



JYOTI BHATT

Spring in Delhi is the season of art. Galleries in the capital don the evening wear of high art, and the annual art fair is an efflorescence of creativity, leaping out of the booths in a mating dance of canvases and installations. Art parties acquire the aura of pilgrimages, and the delirium is unshakeable—even by an earthquake.

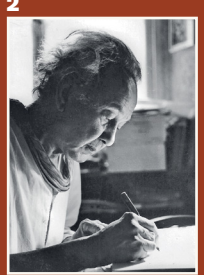
And yet, in the middle of it, in the designer stores-lined service lane of the upmarket Defence Colony in South Delhi, there is an art show that is a counterpoint to all this, replete with Yin energy, like a nun in a meditative retreat. The artworks are on small sheets of paper, mostly with just pen and pencil lines—so delicate, like 'glass placed in water', that they can't be photographed by phone cameras. To see them, you need to come close, immerse yourself.

As you get in the range and the eye begins to discern the delicate line forms, you enter the artwork with a gasp and discover the brilliance of Nasreen Mohamedi (1937-1990), one of the pioneers of modern art in India and one of the first artists to use the vocabulary of modern abstraction in post-Independence India. The show brings together, for the first time, a collection of 40 artworks by this reclusive artist—paintings, drawings and photographs—from the collection of the Glenbarra Art Museum of Japan.

The deliberate and precise lines in the drawings, floating on the white of the paper with subtle shifts in intensity and texture, create seismograph-like patterns that evoke tremulous epiphanies. Like vibrations that are more perceptible than comprehensible. The works have the effect of Zen Koans, questions that defy answers. Art critic Keshav Malik described it as "a musical score for inner ears". In several works, the rhythmic flow of lines is



1



2



4



3

AN ARTIST'S UNIVERSE
(1) "A Marathi Girl Guarding a Jowar Field", 1947; (2) S.H. Raza; (3) "Bindu", 2000
(4) "Saurashtra", 1983

ART

Brushstrokes through Time

A new volume takes us through S.H. Raza's life while tracing the evolution of his art

Sayed Haidar Raza was one of India's most important painters. This eponymous volume has been brought out in tandem with the opening of a major retrospective of Raza's work at the Centre Pompidou, Paris, in his centenary year. Across a long life (1922-2016) and a career stretching across 70-odd years, Raza produced a variety of wonderful work, most of it made in France, his second home. His oeuvre encompasses a whole history of modern art, from Impressionism in the 19th century, the most skilful academic renderings from Indian art schooling of the 1940s, the early-20th-century movements of Fauvism, German

Photo courtesy: (1) ASHVITA'S, CHENNAI; (2) THE RAZA FOUNDATION; (3 and 4) KIRAN NADAR MUSEUM OF ART